

The Victim at Sunrise - A short Carcosa Story

"I open my eyes and are greeted not with my bedroom, but with a strange land where the grass is a permanent, dying brown and the sky is a deep, surreal purple. I look around, not understanding how I got here. In the distance I see a lake full with purple water. I don't know why but it just looks cold. Like if its touched it'll turn to ice. I start to walk around and find myself at a small cave mouth. I go inside. Turning around I can still see that lake in the distance, I must not have walked as far as I thought. I see a small stone tablet, written on it is "Noli secundum actum legere. Scit te hic adesse. Non est tempus explicationibus. Noli eum legere. Ianuam inveni, sicut ego quoque feci. Carcosam relinque." I don't understand what it means. I start to sit down.

As I sit down I notice the twin suns starting to fall below the horizon and the purple sky slowly starts to turn to a deep, hypnotising blue. As it does, the night sky is lit up with hundreds of black stars, that seem to twinkle with ancient sorrow, yet with new light and a renewed curiosity, what they are curious of I cannot tell. I look behind me, expecting to see one or two moons, but I see many. They don't seem to rise or fall but, instead, circle in the sky. I can see them but I cannot count them. The only thing I can know is that there is at least one moon. But as I try to count I fail. I go from 1 to 20 to 10 to 5, there could be more than 100 or less than 37. I can see 1. I think I see more. But I don't know. Maybe there are none. Maybe they're all in my head. Usually I'd get bored looking off into the night sky, yet this one feels unique in a way and still boring in another. Like it's both new and old. Decaying and growing. Alive and dead. All at once.

What could've been hours or days later I see the twin suns start to rise once again, and the circling moon or moons start to fade into darkness. The sunrise is a mix of purples and blues that make my eyes burn yet make me want to look and open my eyes as wide as possible. As I look at it I see a figure start to emerge. It's a tall, slender shadow at first but when it catches the light I see its long, flowing yellow robes that feel more like water than cloth. It doesn't seem to have a face, yet a beautiful one, it feels like it is beckoning me from its distance, calling me to come closer. In its hand is a small book, 'The King in Yellow.' The book feels unnatural, wrong even. But it feels like I want to run over to that figure

and take it for myself. This place, this figure it reminds me of something I cannot remember.

As I begin to stand up and walk towards the figure I feel my body and mind fighting to go back. But I go forward. It's like I'm not even moving myself, like I am a passenger. As I get closer the twin suns split into four then combine into one and split again, the moon or moons fade in and out and the figure stretches and distorts like it's being pulled and squished like playdough. I continue to walk. I eventually reach a lake separating us but I don't care and continue to walk. The purple water feels like at any moment it might freeze. But it doesn't.

After walking for what could've been mere seconds or many long years I step out of the lake, the figure appears to be only a few 10 meters in front of me, yet also so close I could touch it. I continue forward. After a while I bump into the figure, it still looks meters away. I step back and I feel my hand drift toward the book, it appears to stretch meters more then it should be able to to grab it. I start to read.

I get closer to the end of Act 1, hearing of Strangers, Masks, and people such as Camilla. The act is disturbingly beautiful, unique yet banal. It feels safe. It feels like a long lost home. It feels like a second family. I turn the page to act 2. I feel a wave of disgust and terror, like I'm looking at my own death. I laugh. I don't know why. My head is filled with incredible, agonizing pain that makes me want to drop dead. I look at the figure again and the pain fades away, but only slightly.

I know. I know it all. Everything that will be. Everything that once was. Everything that now is. It feels like if I look away from this figure my mind will fall apart. I know everything about the 'real' world, everything. How it ends how I end but nothing, nothing about this place except that it might exist somewhere that is here and not here at once. As I look into the figures void of a face a name floats in and out of my mind, 'King Hastur' I don't know what it means. 'King Hastur' I whisper, the figure responds by disappearing. The pain floods back in. The dam that was the figure has disappeared.

The world snaps back to it's unnatural normality. No more flickering moons or splitting suns. Just the 2 twins and the purple sky. I blink. Why did I do that, why did I read this book? I didn't want to. That figure

must've made me. What does it matter now though? My mind feels like it's trying to burst out of my skull. The pain feels like I was hit with a thousand trucks. It is hundreds if not thousands of times worse than anything I've felt before. I fall to the ground, looking up at the sky. Hastur looms over me, the face is still a void but I feel it is disappointed. One last name flashes through my mind before I feel my mind tearing itself apart. 'Carcosa'

~~My~~ The End."